constructively engage with design engineers and have an ‘aesthetic eye’ for the needs of the customers because of the years he spent at the university.

Ratan’s life as a student at Cornell was exciting. Most of his weekends were devoted to the pursuit of his passion—flying. ‘He got along awfully well with other people. He was well-liked,’ recalls Jack Squier, one of Ratan’s professors. Ratan was also known for his kindness and readiness to help his classmates. Jay Pinchbeck, a fellow Cornellian, remembers how Ratan helped him reorganize his study, which resulted in him getting higher grades. He adds: ‘I’ll be forever grateful to him for that.’ He also participated in the college cultural activities. On one occasion, when it was decided that the girls in the class should pair with the boys and they should act like husbands and wives, he was in demand. ‘A Sri Lankan woman agreed to play the bride, but she said she would do so only if she got to pick the groom. And she picked Tata,’ recalls Nan, Ratan’s classmate. He was particularly popular amongst the five girls who had enrolled in the architecture course in 1958. The shy Ratan did not, however, find a steady girlfriend at Cornell. Occasionally he would manage a date.

While at Cornell, Ratan convinced his father to get him a car. And when it came, it was a black Mercedes-Benz 190, with its colour lending ‘itself to the image of a limousine’, Ratan recalls. The car was shipped directly from Germany. He was exhilarated with the new acquisition and tended to it as his prized possession. He hand-washed the car carefully to prevent any scratches on it. He made sure that ‘the surface was pristine’, recalled Handler. He was so sensitive and fastidious that when anyone shut the door with a bang, it immediately elicited an anguished instruction from Ratan: ‘Don’t slam the door!’ It became a kind of joke among his friends, and they teased him for it.

In the US, it was the American muscle cars—big vehicles with powerful V8 engines—that caught Ratan’s fancy. He sustains this passion with undying fervour even today. The more visible signs of this enduring weakness are, of course, the select cars that are neatly parked on the lower floors of his residence, Halekai.

At university, Ratan lost no opportunity to enjoy the thrill of driving. One ride was, however, particularly eventful. Ratan had a friend, Jack Voevodsky from Tucson, Arizona, who owned a ‘stunning sports car’, the Austin-Healey 100—a white coupe convertible capable of accelerating from 0 to 60 mph in under 12 seconds. One Sunday, the two decided to go